Salimbene de Adam — Cronica (c. 1282–1288)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Salimbene de Adam of Parma, the wandering Franciscan who saw his century close up and wrote it down as he found it: travelling, listening, judging, and remembering. He was an eyewitness to Frederick II's Italy, to Louis IX's France, and to the Joachimite fever of his own order, and from 1282 he wrote his *Cronica* until his death. His other works, including *The Twelve Calamities of Emperor Frederick II*, are lost, which makes the survival of this one voice the more precious. The record in this presentation notes that he stopped because he died, not because his century ran out of incident. This presentation is dedicated to the chronicler who is present on his own pages as more formal writers are not, and whose annals deserve to be heard at their full length.

The story

Salimbene de Adam (1221–c. 1290) was a wandering Franciscan of Parma who saw his century close up. He was an eyewitness to Frederick II's Italy, to Louis IX's France, and to the Joachimite fever of his own order — the intense expectation, following the teachings associated with Joachim of Fiore, that a new age of the world was at hand. From 1282 until his death he wrote his *Cronica*, yearly annals covering 1168 to 1288. It is often described as the most gossipy, human, and quotable chronicle of the thirteenth century, and its author is present on its pages in a way that more formal chroniclers are not: travelling, listening,

judging, and remembering. His other works, including *The Twelve Calamities of Emperor Frederick II*, are lost.

This file is included on an honestly stated basis, and the basis matters. The *Cronica* has been translated into English, completely, in modern times. What has never been made whole is a free, public-domain English version that any reader may open without paying a scarce-book price. This research does not claim the work was never translated, and no edition arising from it should claim that either.

The work and what survives

The Latin text rests on the standard editions: the Monumenta Germaniae Historica *Scriptores*, and Scalia's *Cronica* (Laterza, 1966), which is in copyright as an edition, while the medieval text itself is in the public domain. Early printings — Parma 1857, and Cantarelli's *Cronaca* — circulate as scans. The text is public domain material: a thirteenth-century author and work, to be taken from a public-domain printing or the MGH text.

A reviewer's check pins the usable base precisely. The public-domain Latin base is Holder-Egger's MGH *Scriptores* XXXII edition (Hanover; cited as 1905, 1906, and 1913 across reference works — the exact scan is to be pinned at build time). Scalia's Laterza edition of 1966 is in copyright and is not a usable base; nor is Baird's English.

Its English fortunes

The only complete English translation is by Baird, Baglivi, and Kane (Medieval & Renaissance Texts & Studies, 1986). It is in copyright and scarce, with used copies listed at £300 and more. Against it stands the public-domain English: G. G. Coulton's *From St. Francis to Dante* (1906) — translations of selections, with other sources interleaved. The Catholic Encyclopedia calls Coulton expressly an "incomplete" English translation, and the Internet Archive copy is the 1907 second edition (`2edfromstfrancis00couluoft`).

The bounded finding of this research, verified on 14 October 2026, is this: **No complete public-domain English translation found after research.** That is the pattern of a complete in-copyright version standing beside a free classic that was never made whole, and this file is filed on that basis, honestly labelled.

What completing it would take

Completing the work, in the build shape adopted here from a reviewer's check, means completing Coulton: translating the passages Coulton omitted, from the MGH text, in Coulton's sequence, issued as *Coulton completed* — Coulton credited up front, and the new material clearly marked. A fresh translation from the Latin, annal by annal — the Frederick II years first, as the heart of it — remains the underlying labour, with Coulton's public-domain selections serving as a check-text where they overlap. The review standard set for it is a medieval Latinist. Chronicle length is the cost; the annals divide naturally.

Salimbene wrote until his death, and stopped because he died, not because his century ran out of incident. A complete English *Cronica* that any reader may freely open would let that voice be heard at its full length — selections have carried it, honourably, for more than a hundred years, but selections are what they are.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Salimbene_di_Adam (the Cronica, its span and composition; the 1986 Baird/Baglivi/Kane edition in the bibliography; the lost works)
- https://www.abebooks.co.uk/servlet/SearchResults?an=joseph%20baird&ds=30&tn=chronicle%20salimbene%20adam (the 1986 complete English, MRTS, and its scarcity pricing)
- http://www.italyonthisday.com/2018/10/salimbene-di-adam-historian.html (life, travels, the chronicle 1168–1288, the lost Twelve Calamities)
- https://studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/tce/s/salimbene-degli-adami.html
- https://archive.org/details/2edfromstfrancis00couluoft
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Salimbene_di_Adam